

Windows Batch Files for R

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Introduction

This document describes a number of Windows batch, javascript and `.hta` files that may be used in conjunction with R. Each is self contained and independent of the others. None requires installation - just place on the Windows path or in current directory.¹

`R.bat` is used to run R without permanently modifying the Windows registry. It can also be useful on systems with restricted access to the registry. To configure it simply modify the `set R_HOME` line near the top to point to the current version of R you wish to use.

`movedir.bat` and `copydir.bat` are used for moving or copying packages from one library to another such as when R is upgraded to a new version. There is nothing specific to R in these. They simply move or copy the files from one directory to another. I don't use these any more since I find that I collect numerous packages that I no longer use and prefer to start with a fresh slate on each new version of R.

`el.js` runs its arguments in elevated mode (i.e. with Administrator privileges).

`clip2r.js` copies the current clipboard into a running R instance. It can be used with `vim` or other text editor.

R.bat

Purpose

The purpose of `R.bat` is to run R from the Windows `cmd` line while eliminating the need to make any registry changes.

Typical Usage

Typical usage of `R.bat` to launch R gui is the following²:

¹To display the Windows path enter `path` without arguments at the Windows `cmd` line. To display the path to the current directory enter `cd` without arguments at the Windows `cmd` line.

²If `R.exe` were on the Windows path and before `R.bat` then it would have to be written as follows: `R.bat gui`

`R gui`

This runs `Rgui.exe`. If further arguments are specified they are passed on to `Rgui.exe`. For example,

`R gui --help`

will run:

`Rgui.exe --help`

Subcommands

Running

`R help`

will show usage information. The first argument is a subcommand so `R gui` starts the R gui, `R dir` lists the directories in the R directory (one for each version of R you have installed), `R cd` changes to the R directory, `R show` shows the environment variable blues that `R.bat` is using (as well as any other environment variables that begin with R).

```
> R help
```

```
Usage: R [command] [args...]
```

Core R Executables (Default is 'r'):

<code>r</code>	- Runs R.exe console
<code>gui</code>	- Spawns Rgui.exe
<code>cmd</code>	- Runs Rcmd.exe
<code>term</code>	- Runs Rterm.exe
<code>script</code>	- Runs Rscript.exe
<code>setreg</code>	- Runs RSetReg.exe

Tcl/Tk Shells (Dynamic Version Discovery):

<code>tclsh</code>	- Runs internal tclsh*.exe
<code>wish</code>	- Spawns internal wish*.exe GUI

Utilities:

<code>cd</code>	- Opens a command prompt at the parent directory (C:\Program Files\R)
<code>dir</code>	- Lists files in the parent directory
<code>show</code>	- Displays active environment variables starting with 'R'
<code>help</code>	- Displays this help details

Selecting R Version

To configure the R.bat edit it with a text editor and change the value of R_HOME to point to the root of the tree of the version of R you want it to invoke. For example:

```
set "R_HOME=C:\Program Files\R\R-4.5"
```

If you have multiple versions of R that you want to access at the same time make a copy of R.bat with a new name and set the `set R_HOME` line to the relevant version of R in each.

el.js

`el.js` runs its arguments elevated (i.e. with Administrator privileges). For example, if you have Rtools installed and on your PATH then:

```
el touch "C:\Program Files\R\R-4.5"
```

The user will be prompted to allow elevation to proceed.

clip2r.js

This program writes the clipboard into the running Rgui session. It can be used with `vim` or other text editor.

Here is the exact keystroke breakdown:

Set the focus to Rgui and then send these keys to it:

`%` (Alt + Space): Opens the native Windows system menu (the window management menu in the top-left corner of the window frame).

`x`: Selects Maximize from that menu to force the window into full screen.

`%{w}` (Alt + W): Opens the Rgui Windows menu.

`1` Types the literal number 1 selecting R Console from the Windows menu.

`^{v}` (Ctrl + V): Executes a standard Paste command, dumping whatever text payload is currently sitting in your Windows clipboard straight into the active input line.

See the source for additional instructions.

make-batchfiles-pdf.bat

This batch file, which is mainly for my own use, creates **batchfiles.pdf** from the markdown file **batchfiles.md** . **pandoc** must be installed for this to run. It is run without arguments:

```
make-batchfiles-pdf
```